SBP: Rebuilding Homes And Restoring Hope

www.sbpusa.org

This interview was conducted with Carol Markowitz, CEO, SBP

Twenty years ago, in the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina, a small volunteer team found itself in New Orleans, compelled by an urgent need they could not ignore: efficient, fair, and timely rebuilding for underserved communities.

In March 2006, that commitment became the St. Bernard Project (now known as SBP). Their efforts were concentrated in St. Bernard Parish, where the storm left 68,000 people homeless, and the area was almost completely submerged.

Today, SBP is a leading disaster recovery nonprofit headquartered in New Orleans. It's more than just building homes. SBP aids in transforming disaster from tragedy to strength, helping the hardest-hit homeowners and communities to emerge stronger than before. Since its inception, SBP has done this with a unique disaster recovery program model, returning over 6,700 families to their homes across the country. Alongside its recovery work, SBP now works with high-risk, low-capacity communities and governments, helping them prepare for and respond to disasters through training and advisory services.

SBP's existence speaks to recovery beginning with the community. Twenty years later, SBP's reach is an amazing testament to how New Orleans turned tragedy into a source of strength.

Q: Why is there a need for this type of resource for New Orleans and the surrounding areas?

Carol Markowitz: In a place like New Orleans, there's a need for both kinds of work that SBP does. Meaning, we live in a part of the country that regularly faces a hurricane season and has a long history of being on the receiving end of major natural disasters. And so, it is important that cities like ours work toward making sure we have the information, capacity, and resources truly needed to ensure that our citizens are prepared to both withstand and recover from a natural disaster. Furthermore, we are in a place where people lack access to and/or don't have adequate insurance, nor the extra wealth and resources needed to cover the costs of recovery [after a major natural disaster like a hurricane].

Q: How has the grant and partnership from BCM supported SBP's goals over the past year?

Markowitz: We used the funding from the BCM last year to help 41 low-income, under-insured New Orleans families rebuild their homes resiliently, ending months and in some cases years of uncertainty. Grants like these are so important because there is still far too much of an imbalance between other alternative sources of funding to meet the need or the demand for the work.

Q: What do you think city leaders need to know about some of the challenges you face as a non-profit organization that is responsible for providing such a valuable resource to support community housing and infrastructure in metropolitan New Orleans?

Markowitz: Along with our partners (e.g., New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity and the United Way of South Louisiana), we are trying to get [support] for a roofing collective to advance progress on more equitable access to fortified roofs for low-income homeowners here. We are trying to share with the local administration some lessons that we have collectively learned while working with the State of Louisiana's Department of Insurance's grant program for these low-income households. We understand there is a possibility for the city to engage in some policies and programs that align with advancing further adoption of fortified roofing and ensuring equitable access to that [opportunity]. So, this is an area where we are really looking forward to working with the city and our partners, to [hopefully] avoid some of the challenges we experienced with the state's program; but also, just to lean in to the pool of expertise that resides in some of the other local organizations who have been doing this work for years now.

Q: Can you speak to an inspirational moment that resonates with you and speaks to why you are passionate about this type of work?

Markowitz: I began my role as CEO about a year ago at SBP. My first volunteer experience was actually with Sister Regina Marie, shortly after I started last year, and it was a really touching experience to sit with her and hear many of her stories. She's been one of SBP's biggest boosters and a long-standing

volunteer and organizer, especially among her Catholic sisters nationally and the Ursulines Academy network globally. And what she reminds me of is that at our core, [SBP's] mission is about creating hope for people. There's also a profound quote she's left with us: 'We are building not only houses, but hearts.' And that's really why I took this job. I like hard work, but I also like heart work. And that's probably true about everybody who works at SBP. We care about our shared sense of humanity, and we understand what it means to live in places like New Orleans that have to deal with some significant climate challenges. So, it inspires us to press forward, despite all of the challenges in our work.

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